

A Cook's Tour

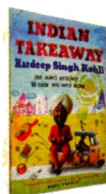
A Sikh from Glasgow journeys across the country in search of his roots—and spices

By Dilip Bobb

Why would a middle-aged Sikh born and raised in Glasgow, Scotland, elect to, literally, undertake a cook's tour of India, preparing British food for Indian palates? Hardeep Singh Kohli's culinary ambition remains largely unfulfilled—even the British gave up on their cuisine years ago—but his pan-Indian journey is a bubbling, broiling stew of adventures and misadventures that makes for a spicy literary dish. Kohli is a radio and television broadcaster in the UK and a chef who needs to discover which of his dual identities, British and Indian, really define who he is.

As a "bastard child of East and West, chronicler of the contemporary", he manages to serve up a chronicle simmering with humour and self-discovery as well as entertaining insights into India and, incidentally, himself, a "Punjabi Sikh Glaswegian who also feels some empathy with being British". It's an ethnic paradox he doesn't quite resolve but has a lot of fun trying as he crosses the country. He travels by bus, trains, planes, two-wheelers and taxis driven by suicidal "nutters" and after discovering that dishes like steak and kidney pie don't have many takers in the hotels, restaurants and homes he visits, decides to just enjoy the ride. It's quite a ride, covering popular beaches and cities, obscure villages, remote farms and his ancestral home in Ferozepur where he completes his journey of discovery and self-discovery.

Kohli has a fierce Punjabi passion for food and much of the book is about dishes, either made in the kitchen of his Glasgow home, or the preparation and composition of local and regional dishes he tastes in the places he travels to in India. He is no Anthony Bourdain, looking for extreme culinary experiences, just a hefty Sikh NRI with a hefty appetite for life who has the good fortune to be able to combine his two passions, travel and food, and in the process try to unravel his true identity. Kohli has a flair for the written word, not just alphabet soup, and his frequent use of British slang makes for an enjoyable literary concoction. His observations, part as outsider, part insider, are witty and perceptive but it is his descriptive ability about people he meets and places he stays at which really lifts this book beyond just a food-related travelogue. It's the literary equivalent of a typical Punjabi dish, dollops of spicy ingredients stirred together with substantial chunks of meat, indeed much like Britain's favourite dish: Chicken Tikka Masala.



INDIAN TAKEAWAY
by HARDEEP SINGH KOHLI
HarperCollins
Price: Rs 295
Pages: 285

TOP 10

A monthly list of national bestselling books compiled for INDIA TODAY by ORG-MARG

FICTION

1. The White Tiger
Aravind Adiga, HarperCollins
2. The 3 Mistakes of My Life
Chetan Bhagat, Rupa
3. The Tales of Beedle the Bard
J.K. Rowling, Bloomsbury
4. Twilight: Film Tie-in
Stephenie Meyer, Atom / Hachette Book
5. The Rozabal Line
Ashwin Sanghi, Westland

NON-FICTION

1. Imagining India: Ideas for the New Century
Nandan Nilekani, Penguin
2. Stay Hungry, Stay Foolish
Rashmi Bansal, CIE, IIM-Ahmedabad
3. The Secret
Rhonda Byrne, Atria
4. Outliers: The Story of Success
Malcolm Gladwell, Allen Lane
5. Curfewed Night
Basharat Peer, Random House

OTHER INDIAN BOOKS IN THE TOP 20

FICTION

6. Sea of Poppies
Amitav Ghosh, Penguin/Viking
7. Between the Assassinations
Aravind Adiga, Picador
8. Unaccustomed Earth
Jhumpa Lahiri, Random House India

NON-FICTION

11. The 24x7 Marriage: Smart Strategies for Good Beginnings
Vijay Nagaswami, Westland
14. Chicken Soup For The Indian Soul
Jack Canfield, Westland
17. Go Kiss the World
Subroto Bagchi, Penguin

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